SPORTS
Surfing

India Rides A New Wave

SURFING MAY BE JUST A DECADE OLD AS A COMPETITIVE SPORT IN INDIA, BUT ATHLETES ARE ALREADY LOOKING TO MAKE A SPLASH AT THIS YEAR'S ASIAN GAMES

BY SUHANI SINGH

A sunny, humid day late in May, Tannirbhavi Beach in Mangaluru, Karnataka, was a postcard-pretty picture, though with two competing moods. On one side of the beach was a gaggle of gleeful tourists, flapping about in the water and enjoying time away from work with family and friends; on the other, a string of steely-eyed youngsters, looking regal in wetsuits and atop surf boards, monitoring the waves for the perfect moment to show off their moves in front of the Surfing Federation of India (SFI) jury. This was the seventh edition of the Indian Open of Surfing, but this year, the stakes were higher—the results would determine who would be heading to Japan for the Asian Games in September. Of more than 50 hopefuls, two men and two women would be selected for the tournament where surfing, already an Olympic sport since the 2021 edition, finally makes its Asiad debut.

A month later, SFI confirmed the names. Although surfers from the east coast (mostly Tamil Nadu) faction dominate the squad, edging out their old rivals from the west coast (mostly Karnataka), what unites the stories of all those who fought it out on this beach is their beginnings: kids living by the coast and their initial trepidation of water; a bond forged with the ocean by learning to swim

Photographs courtesy: PRAVEEN JAYAKARAN (SURFING SWAMI FOUNDATION)